Ricochet

by Jane Nicolaas



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MAYA. Excuse me, Doctor Keller?

ELI. Ms. Miller?

MAYA. Maya, please.

ELI. Maya. It's nice to see you. How's your father?

MAYA. He's great, well, thanks to you.

ELI. I don't know about all that.

MAYA. No, I'm serious. You made all the difference.

ELI. (*blushes*) Well, I'm just glad I could help.

MAYA. Well, look…I came here because, well…I saw that you had a St. Louis Rams cover on your phone and I…I bought two tickets to the game this Sunday. I thought maybe we could go, if you wanted.

ELI. Maya, wow. I'm flattered, but…uh…

MAYA. You're married.

ELI. No.

MAYA. Girlfriend?

ELI. No.

MAYA. Gay?

ELI. No! It's just… I'm not supposed to date patients.

MAYA. Oh… Then I guess it's a good thing my dad isn't asking you out.

ELI. Okay. Sunday. You and me. That sounds fun. Can I come pick you up?

MAYA. Sure, that'd be nice, Doc.

ELI. Are you in downtown St. Louis? Or where do you live?

MAYA. I live in over in Ferguson.

INTRO

ELI. Knock, knock? Maya?

MAYA. Hey. I'm in back.

ELI. Wow. The shop looks amazing. It's really coming together.

MAYA. Think so?

ELI. It's wonderful. The grand opening is going to be one heck of a party. Am I invited?

MAYA. Of course you are, silly.

ELI. Well, it's just that I don't want to be a distraction.

MAYA. Why? Cuz you'll be the only white guy?

ELI. No. I meant I'd be a distraction to you.

MAYA. Right, of course. Ignore me. I'm just stressed out about inventory.

ELI. I could never ignore you. In fact… (*pulls a bunch of flowers from behind his back*) These are for you. Happy anniversary!

MAYA. You are such a nerd.

ELI. Yeah.

MAYA. Well, thanks, Doc.

ELI. We've been together for six months. Don't you think you could call me by my name instead of my title?

MAYA. But you paid so much for it.

ELI. Ha.

MAYA. Eli, I've been thinking about something…

ELI. Okay.

MAYA. I'm…I'm in love with you.

ELI. Don't sound so thrilled.

MAYA. No, no it's not that. I am thrilled. You're amazing. It's all the other stuff that worries me.

ELI. Other stuff?

MAYA. It's just…the stares on the street, the way waiters always ask if we'll need separate checks, your neighbors never—

ELI. Hey, listen to me. All of that is crap. This. You and me. That's what's real. Maya, I look at you and I don't see the color of your skin. I see a beautiful, smart, kind, and lovely woman whom I…well, you can read the card with the flowers.

MAYA. *(She does. It says he loves her.)* Hmm. Such a nerd.

ELI. Indeed. Now then, how about you find a vase for those and I'll pop the cork on some wine, find a good song on the radio and I'll help you stock inventory.

MAYA. Happy six month anniversary?

ELI. The happiest. (*He kisses her and she leaves. He turns the radio on.*)

RADIO. *And in local news, a police shooting has left an 18-year-old black teenager dead. While the details of the case have not been released, it has been reported that the 18-year-old, Michael Brown, was unarmed.*

MAYA. (*enters*) God. That's awful.

ELI. It is. Terrible. But I think… (*he switches the radio to music*) This isn't so bad. (*he pulls her to him and starts to dance*)

MAYA. Eli…

ELI. One dance, and then we'll do inventory. Promise.

TRANSITION

RADIO. *Rioting continues in Ferguson as citizens demand justice for the slain Michael Brown. Severe damages and looting has been reported. The National Guard has been called in.*

MAYA. Eli?

ELI. Thank god. I've been trying to call you for hours.

MAYA. Why?

ELI. Here. Take my keys. Get your Dad, and go to my house.

MAYA. No, it's fine.

ELI. You'll be safe there. I'll be home as soon as I can, but the emergency room has been flooded with these idiot rioters.

MAYA. I don't want to hide in your apartment.

ELI. We'll go by the shop once this insanity calms down. I'm sure everything's fine, but you never know with mobs of people running around and causing all kinds of—what are you wearing?

MAYA. "Hands Up, Don't Shoot" It's the protest slogan.

ELI. Yeah. I've heard it on the radio. Is that where you were? You were out there in that craziness?

MAYA. It wasn't that crazy. I mean, I know the news makes it look bad, but most of us are just marching and peacefully demonstrating.

ELI. Most of "us?"

MAYA. Yeah. My dad is out there with me and my neighbors. There's a lot of people who are standing up to this.

ELI. (*uncomfortable*) Okay…

MAYA. Maybe you can join us after work?

ELI. I won't be done until morning.

MAYA. Something tells me we'll still be out there. (*kisses his cheek*) Bye. (*she leaves*)

ELI. Love you, too.

TRANSITION

RADIO. *The Justice Department announces that it will open a broad civil rights investigation. Citizens have been galvanized by the inquiry and are calling for sweeping changes to the police force and the community at large declaring "Black Lives Matter."*

ELI. (*on the telephone*) Maya?

MAYA. Eli?

ELI. Where are you? I can barely hear you.

MAYA. Eli? Hang on. Sorry, we are outside the courthouse.

ELI. I'm at the restaurant.

MAYA. You didn't get my email?

ELI. The one about you not coming to the restaurant? I guess not.

MAYA. Are you mad?

ELI. I just—

MAYA. Look, I am sorry. This is important.

ELI. So am I.

MAYA. What? Look, I can't hear you, Doc. I'll call you back later.

TRANSITION

RADIO. *The grand jury still hasn't reached a decision around whether or not to indict Officer Darren Wilson in the shooting of Michael Brown. But both racial tensions in Ferguson have reached a fevered pitch.*

ELI. (*turns off the radio*) God, isn't there anything else to talk about?

MAYA. …

ELI. I just meant, you know. It's been three months.

MAYA. And you're ready to move on.

ELI. Yes. I mean, no. That sounds callous.

MAYA. Yes, it does.

ELI. Hey, come on. I didn't mean it like that. I just hate seeing everyone so unhappy. Especially you. I mean, when was the last time I got you to laugh, huh?

MAYA. I don't really feel like laughing. This isn't something you can laugh off.

ELI. (*gives up and gets frustrated*) Okay. Fine.

MAYA. 92% of all people arrested in Ferguson last year were black.

ELI. Right.

MAYA. Despite the fact that only 65% of the community is black.

ELI. Are you done?

MAYA. And nationally, 98.9% of excessive force allegations are ultimately ruled as justified.

ELI. Maya, stop it!

MAYA. Why? Does it make you uncomfortable?

ELI. Hey! It is awful what happened. A cop, taught to shoot first, and a kid who got caught in the crossfire. It's all awful, but I don't—

MAYA. A *white* cop taught to shoot first at a *black* kid.

ELI. Yeah…and?

MAYA. You don't think that has anything to do with you and me?

ELI. Just because there are ignorant people in the world doesn't mean you and I change.

MAYA. Eli—

ELI. Yes, racism is real. I get that.

MAYA. Eli—

ELI. But I've told you before, I don't see color.

MAYA. Maybe you should! I am black! It's not something you should ignore.

ELI. What?! Because I *don't* pay attention to your race, I'm a racist?

MAYA. I didn't say that. But all you white people act the same around this…

ELI. *Us white people?!*

MAYA. Like racism is some bad penny that keeps showing up in your pocket. "I thought we got rid of this," you say. So you shove it down and bury it, but it doesn't go away.

ELI. It doesn't go away because people don't let it go away.

MAYA. People?

ELI. Well, it certainly isn't "us white people."

MAYA. Now you're just being a jackass.

ELI. Oh, am I?

MAYA. Yes, you're being an ignorant jackass.

ELI. Well, it beats being a martyr. I am sorry, but I am not going to stand here and have you tell me that I am racist meanwhile *you're* the one who can't stop talking about the color of *my* skin.

MAYA. I can't stop talking because you won't start talking, Eli.

ELI. What do you want from me, Maya?

MAYA. I don't know… I want you to acknowledge that there is a problem and that it involved everybody.

ELI. Why do you want that?

MAYA. Because I want to make a difference. Don't you?

ELI. No! I don't want to make a difference. I want a relationship. But it sure as hell looks like that's not happening.

TRANSITION

RADIO. *Protestors have restlessly gathered outside the courthouse and the Ferguson police station in anxious anticipation of the grand jury's verdict.*

ELI. Maya?

MAYA. What are you doing here?

ELI. Look, I know that you're probably still mad at me.

MAYA. Probably?

ELI. Okay. You're pissed. But…look, I thought about what you said. You were right. I figured I wasn't part of the problem and that made me part of the solution, but that's not true. I get that now.

MAYA. You do?

ELI. I tried to put myself in your place. I tried to see all of this from your eyes, but I couldn't. I didn't understand it, so I just…ignored it. But that's just it, isn't it? Evil stuff doesn't happen because the world is full of evil people. It happens because the world is full of passive people who think that the bad stuff has nothing to do with them. I don't want to be passive. I don't want to be ignorant. I…I don't know what to say. I don't know a lot of things. But I do know that you being black isn't just something I tolerate. It's part of who you are, and who you are is who I am desperately in love with.

MAYA. Good speech.

ELI. Yeah? I thought it got a little rough in the middle. It was better when I practiced in the car.

MAYA. You're such a nerd.

ELI. I am.

MAYA. This isn't something that goes away, Eli. This is a conversation we will always have – consciously and unconsciously.

ELI. Okay. I can accept that. As long as you're willing to accept that I won't know what to say a lot of the time.

MAYA. So, sorta how most of our other conversations go anyhow?

ELI. Ha.

MAYA. You might not know what to say, but that doesn't mean you stop talking, okay?

ELI. I promise.

MAYA. I do love you, Doc.

ELI. I love you, too.

RADIO. *No matter the outcome of the grand jury decision, one thing is certain: the world should and will be a different place after today.*